

# The Boston Globe

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‘The idea itself is the right one, and we definitely support it. But there are questions that we need to discuss.’

PRESIDENT VLADIMIR PUTIN

## Putin says he’s open to truce, with conditions

Zelensky calls response ‘very manipulative’

By Anton Troianovski

NEW YORK TIMES

BERLIN — President Vladimir Putin of Russia on Thursday did not rule out a US and Ukrainian proposal for a monthlong cease-fire, but he set down numerous conditions that would most likely delay any truce — or could make one impossible to achieve.

Putin’s comments during a news conference highlighted the balance he was trying to strike, exuding confidence in Russia’s position on the battlefield while seeking to continue talks with the United States and avoid upsetting President Trump. The US president, having antagonized the country’s allies and realigned American foreign policy in Russia’s favor, has emerged as a key geopolitical partner for Putin.

In sharp remarks later in the day, President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine said the Russian leader set so many conditions “that nothing will work out at all or that it will not work out for as long as possible.”

Putin’s comments came before he was to meet with Steve Witkoff, Trump’s Middle East envoy, to discuss the cease-fire proposal that Ukraine had already agreed to. As of early Friday Moscow time, the Kremlin had not com-

PUTIN, Page A4

## A power struggle in Cambridge

Love ’em or hate ’em, gas leaf blowers now (mostly) banned

By Spencer Buell

GLOBE STAFF

CAMBRIDGE — The days of the gas-powered leaf blower are numbered here.

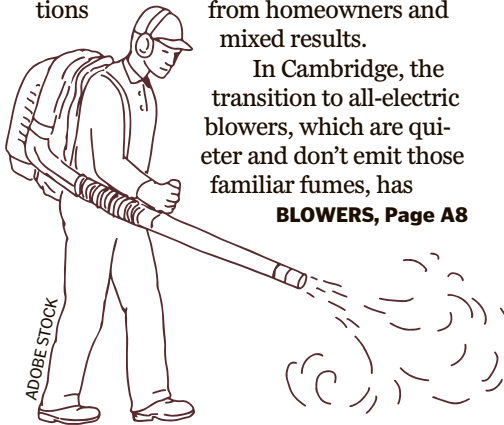
As of Saturday, a long-discussed — and celebrated and hated — ban on the devices begins to take effect in the city, making it illegal for people to use them on their own property. Instead, they’ll have to use devices powered either by rechargeable batteries or via electrical cords.

Next year, the ban applies to professional landscapers, too, and, as you might imagine, they are not necessarily thrilled about the shift.

Prohibitions of this kind have swept through the region as cities try to pare back the use of gas leaf blowers — and their negative impacts on the climate and quality of life — with mixed reactions from homeowners and mixed results.

In Cambridge, the transition to all-electric blowers, which are quieter and don’t emit those familiar fumes, has

BLOWERS, Page A8



## Democrats torn as shutdown looms

Got a problem? Call Musk!  
\* Republicans only

By Sam Brodey

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — At Elon Musk’s Department of Government Efficiency, there is no official help line for members of Congress to call with questions about how the billionaire’s far-reaching effort to slash federal spending might affect their constituents.

But many Republicans have something better: Musk’s personal cellphone number, or failing that, the numbers of some of his top aides.

“I just call Elon,” said Senator Rick Scott, a Florida Republican, when asked how he

tracks down answers to DOGE-related questions.

Democrats, meanwhile, have nothing at all.

Representative Jake Auchincloss, a Newton Democrat, said that he tried to get in touch with DOGE about a particular concern — he wouldn’t elaborate on the inquiry or explain how he conveyed it — but that “DOGE had every opportunity to engage with me in good faith and stiff-armed me.”

“There is,” Auchincloss said, “no DOGE 311.”

According to interviews with more than a dozen law-

MUSK, Page A7

**Birthright citizenship**

Trump lawyers have asked the Supreme Court to allow the president’s order ending it to take effect. **A2.**

**Workers to return**

A judge ordered six federal agencies to rehire thousands of fired employees. **A2.**

**Nominee withdrawn**

The choice for CDC director was told the White House didn’t have the votes. **A7.**

Stark choice for senators — keep government open or stand up to GOP

By Jim Puzzanghera

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — For the third time this week, Senate Democrats met for a lengthy lunch Thursday behind closed doors to chew over two political options that are hard for them to swallow: give President Trump and congressional Republicans the votes they need to pass a six-month budget bill with unpalatable provisions or block it and allow the federal government to shut down.

“Pick your poison,” said Senator Peter Welch of Vermont.

For Welch, the best worst option is a vote against the bill, though like all of his colleagues

he stressed he does not want the government to shut down. Other Democrats in the Senate continue to struggle with that dilemma. But with funding set to run out at 12:01 a.m. Saturday, Senate minority leader Chuck Schumer, a New York Democrat, said Thursday night that he would vote to keep the government open.

“It’s a Hobson’s choice: either proceed with the bill before us or risk Donald Trump throwing America into the chaos of a shutdown,” Schumer said on the Senate floor, decrying the legislation but saying a shutdown would be worse.

He later told reporters that Democratic senators were still

SHUTDOWN, Page A7



PHOTOS BY CALEB KENNA FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Green Mountain College in Poultney, Vt., fell victim to the pressures facing so many small schools these days.

## After college, big plans

A wealthy entrepreneur intends to transform the campus of a closed Vt. school. The town that depended on it isn’t so sure.

By Diti Kohli

GLOBE STAFF

POULTNEY, Vt. — Raj Bhakta puffed on a cigar, the smoke dissipating against the windows that overlook the former campus of Green Mountain College. He bought the property after the school closed in 2019 without a solid idea for what it would become, or what its second life would mean for this teensy town on the Vermont-New York line.

“The way to go nuts,” Bhakta said, “is to buy a college campus in the middle of nowhere and then figure out all the things you can do with it.”

Now five years later, Bhakta is charting a future for the institution where he and his family also



The Bhaktas run the Green Mountain Community School, a nontraditional elementary institution on the campus.

live: a \$100 million complex of hotel rooms, condos, and a micro-distillery, according to plans submitted to the state. His wife already runs an independent K-5 school on campus, and Bhakta also has an idea to create a college-level business education program that “goes back to the fundamentals,” he said.

But the loss of Green Mountain College has also been a lesson in patience for Poultney’s 3,000 residents, who are anxiously watching how life in their small town will be transformed by the decisions of a wealthy entrepreneur.

“I just hope the Bhaktas follow through,” said Emily Stockwell, owner of Everyday Flowers in Poultney.

The 185-year-old Green Mountain College was once a leader in sustainability studies,

CAMPUS, Page A8

**A woman who allegedly held her stepson captive for 20 years was arrested,** weeks after firefighters found him. **B1.**

**The talks to extend the Gaza cease-fire were in limbo** as the Trump administration turned its attention elsewhere. **A3.**

**A reckoning on the value of office towers is coming,** five years after COVID upended Boston’s office market. **B5.**

**The new iPhone offers useful entry-level AI features,** but the good stuff is months away, writes Hiawatha Bray. **B5.**

**Massachusetts and 19 other states sued to try to stop the Trump administration** from dismantling the Department of Education. **B1.**

**Rafael Devers attempted to clear the air,** saying he’ll DH if the Red Sox need him to. **C1.**



### Pi in the face

**Friday:** Overcast, cool. High 44-49. Low 37-42,

**Saturday:** Warming up. High 53-58. Low 45-50.

**Weather and Comics, G6-7. Obituaries, C11.**

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